

Belal's big night

Belal Muhammad had secured a statement unanimous decision win over Leon Edwards at UFC 304 last year to clinch the **welterweight title**. He now gears up to defend it for the first time.

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Montreal will play host to the Ultimate Fighting Championship's (UFC) most anticipated fight on May 11 as America's Belal Muhammad gears up to defend his title for the first time. Belal, who made his UFC debut back in 2016, had to wait for his shot at the welterweight title — eight years, to be precise.

And when the opportunity arose, he stepped up and seized it with both hands. True to his nickname 'Remember The Name', Belal secured a statement unanimous decision win over Leon Edwards at UFC 304 to clinch the belt. Like a fine wine, Belal has improved with age and has become a master strategist inside

the cage, combining endurance with relentless pace.

He pairs this suffocating pressure with ever-improving striking technique to systematically break down and overwhelm his opponents. His fight record is indicative of his wait-and-strike approach — just six out of his 24 professional wins have come via finishes and the rest have been decisions. The strategy was evident in his bout against Edwards. **With a total of nine takedowns and 68 significant strikes, Belal dominated his opponent for the majority of the fight and took home a convincing victory.**

That win marked his sixth straight triumph, extending an impressive unbeaten streak that now spans 11 fights over the past five years.

Standing across from him will be Perth's Jack Della Maddalena, a fighter who is also riding a massive wave of momentum. Initially scheduled to face Edwards earlier this year, circumstances now pit him against Belal. Della enters this title opportunity on an incredible 17-fight winning streak in professional MMA.

Since joining the UFC roster after impressing on Dana White's Contender Series (DWCS) in 2021, he has had seven consecutive wins, including five finishes. Belal will likely deliver grappling exchanges with relentless pressure, while Della will rely on his knockout power and finishing instincts. For Della, a victory would make him only the third Australian fighter — after Robert Whittaker and Alexander Volkanovski — to capture UFC gold.

Intense: Belal Muhammad (top) and Leon Edwards during their welterweight title bout. GETTYIMAGES